

Nineveh

Location Mosul, Iraq

The splendor of the Assyrian city of Nineveh was renowned, and skillfully planned. Although founded as early as 6000 BCE, it was transformed into a glorious royal and imperial capital by King Sennacherib in the 7th century BCE. The king erected city walls, gates, temples, palaces, and beautiful public gardens and parks, as well as sophisticated irrigation systems, canals, and aqueducts. His own palace, which he hailed as “the palace without rival,” contained around 80 rooms. He also showcased Assyrian art in all its magnificence. Particularly distinctive were immense statues of animals that guarded the entrances to buildings; inside, spectacular bas-relief panels glorified the triumphs of the empire. Nineveh was sacked and burned in around 612 BCE, when the Assyrian Empire fell to the Medes and the Babylonians.

Ishtar Gate

Location Babylon, Iraq

Constructed in around 575 BCE by King Nebuchadnezzar II, the Ishtar Gate became the eighth fortified gate in the magnificent city of Babylon. It was dedicated to Ishtar, the Mesopotamian goddess of fertility, love, and war. More than 39 ft (12 m) high and built from burned brick, the enormous double gate had a central arch that spanned 25 ft (7.5 m). Brilliant blue glazed tiles—depicting rows of bulls, lions, and dragons—decorated the facade. The gate was built at the start of the Processional Way, an avenue that is thought to have run southward for almost 0.6 miles (1 km).

► RECONSTRUCTED FACADE OF THE ISHTAR GATE DECORATED WITH ANIMAL FIGURES

